Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā. Āsanas (Yoga Kāṇḍa, ch. 1, vv. 67–82)

About the Text and the Purpose of This Document

What the text is. The *Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā* (Yoga Kāṇḍa) is a Sanskrit treatise on yoga, written as a dialogue between the sage Vasiṣṭha and his son Śakti. Śakti asks how to attain the knowledge that frees one from the sufferings of the world and from the fear of birth, old age and death. Vasiṣṭha answers with a teaching which, he says, he himself once received from Brahmā. Scholars date the text to the 12th–13th centuries; the Kaivalyadhāma editors place it at about 1250 (see the introduction on dating for details). The text matters for the history of yoga for two reasons. More than 250 of its verses were taken over into the *Yogayājñavalkya*. And the *Haṭhapradīpikā* (1.18) mentions āsanas adopted by "sages beginning with Vasiṣṭha".

What it describes. Vasiṣṭha holds that liberating knowledge is yoga itself. This yoga has eight parts: yama, niyama, āsana, prāṇāyāma, pratyāhāra, dhāraṇā, dhyāna and samādhi (1.33). He calls the first four external and the last four internal. The material is arranged by chapter as follows:

- **Chapter 1.** Action and knowledge: action performed with knowledge and without desire is liberating. Also ten yamas, ten niyamas and ten āsanas.
- **Chapter 2.** The body from the yogic point of view: the channels (nāḍī) and their purification, the kanda, the vital winds (vāyu), their locations and functions.
- **Chapter 3.** Prāṇāyāma and pratyāhāra.
- **Chapter 4.** Dhāraṇā, dhyāna and samādhi, including five kinds of meditation on a form (saguṇa-dhyāna).
- **Chapter 5.** The nature of the ātman and the signs of approaching death, read from the signs of the zodiac and from the character of the breath.
- **Chapter 6.** How to overcome death.

The manuscripts usually have eight chapters. Chapters 7 and 8 are closer to astrology, so the Kaivalyadhāma edition gives them without translation.

Purpose of this document. The document has two aims:

1. To give a full account of all ten āsanas of the first chapter (verses 67–82): Svastika, Gomukha, Padma, Vīra, Siṃha, Mayūra, Kukkuṭa, Bhadra, Kūrma and Mukta. Each āsana is analysed verse by verse. For each verse the document

gives the Devanāgarī text, the Latin IAST transliteration and a Cyrillic transliteration. These are followed by a word-by-word analysis, a literal translation and a literary translation.

2. To bring together in the introduction everything known about the dating of the text and to examine the arguments for each proposed date. Quotations are given verbatim with exact references, so that every claim can be checked against the primary source.

Source of the text: Vasistha Samhita (Yoga Kanda), Revised Edition, Kaivalyadhama, Lonavla, 2005; ch. 1, pp. 20–24. The chapter contents are summarised from the "Summary of Chapters" section of the same edition.

Source: Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā, Yoga Kāṇḍa, chapter 1, verses 67–82 (edition with English translation, pp. 20–24; text obtained by OCR of scans).

The Devanāgarī and IAST have been checked against each other and cleaned of OCR errors and of the edition's line numbers; all corrections are noted in the word-by-word analysis. The Cyrillic transliteration follows the scheme of the sample.

The order of the āsanas follows the descriptions in the text (in the list in verse 67 Kūrma is named before Bhadrāsana).

Introduction. The Dating of the Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā (Yoga Kāṇḍa)

How to use this section

- Every quotation is given verbatim in the original (English). The page or note number and a link to the text are given, so that each quotation can be found and checked.
- Quotations from the introduction to the Kaivalyadhāma edition were taken from the online copy of the 2005 edition. Its text was produced by OCR of a two-column layout: the columns are mixed with each other and with the chart of the teachers' lineage printed on the same pages. I restored the word order and removed names from the chart that had found their way into the sentences. Omissions are marked [...]; the spelling and misprints of the original are kept. **These quotations must be checked against the printed book.** The printed edition gives names and terms with diacritics (Sūta Saṃhitā, Vasiṣṭha, etc.), while the OCR copy has none, so the spelling in unchecked quotations may

differ from the print. Quotations already checked against the book are marked “Checked against the printed edition”.

- My own observations (not belonging to the authors quoted) are always marked “Compiler's note”.

1. Summary

Proposed date	**Proposed by**	**Basis (in the authors' own words)**
“about 1250 A.D.”; “after the 12th century”	Introduction to the Kaivalyadhāma edition (1984/2005), section Chronology	Halāyudha (1050) and Lakṣmīdhara (1150) do not quote the text; Haṭhapradīpikā 1.18 mentions Vasiṣṭha, and the Haṭhapradīpikā is dated to about 1350
“prior to 1150 A.D.”	Same book, section on the Sūta Saṃhitā (checked against the printed edition)	No justification, only the reference “as shown below”; contradicts the conclusion “about 1250” (see §2.7)
12th–13th centuries	Birch 2011; Birch 2018	Lower limit from the Kaivalyadhāma edition; upper limit the Yogayājñavalkya, which borrows from the Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā and is itself older than the Haṭhapradīpikā (15th c.)
“before 1250”	Wujastyk 2017	References to Bouy 1994 and Birch 2011
12th century	Birch 2020; Gupta & Birch 2022	Reference to the Kaivalyadhāma edition and to the Yogayājñavalkya's borrowings from the Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā
13th century	Mallinson & Singleton 2017 (timeline); Westoby 2024	No detailed justification in the places quoted
A source older than the text itself: the	Wujastyk 2017 (after Colas); Birch 2018	The Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā probably borrowed material from it,

Vimānārcanākalpa, c. 900 / 9th c.		including the section on āsanas

2. The main source: the introduction to the Kaivalyadhāma edition

Edition: *Vasistha Samhita (Yoga Kanda). Revised Edition.* Editors & Commentators: Philosophico-Literary Research Department, Kaivalyadhama S.M.Y.M. Samiti, Lonavla. First Publication: August 1984; Revised Publication: March 2005. ISBN 81-89485-37-7. Editorial board of the revised edition: Swami Maheshananda, B. R. Sharma, G. S. Sahay, R. K. Bodhe. (An even earlier edition in eight chapters was published at Kaivalyadhāma in 1969; this is stated in the preface to the 2005 edition.)

Online copy:
https://doku.pub/documents/vasistha-samhita-yoga-kanda-with-commentary-kaivalya-dhamtext-j0vmm63vve0x

Pages: in the online copy the section "Chronology" falls on pp. 31–33 of the introduction. Birch (2011, n. 8) cites "2005: 30–32", Gupta & Birch (2022) cite "2005: 31–32". The file with the āsana text appears to come from this same edition (ch. I, pp. 20–24).

Checked against the printed edition. The text of the section "Chronology" (§§2.1–2.4 below) has been checked against the printed book, from which it was transcribed in full. Diacritics and spelling follow the printed text. In the online copy the page break falls at the words "…VS is the / later origin" (pp. 31/32 of the online copy).

2.1. Lower limit: early authors do not quote the text (argument from silence)

> "***Chronology***
>
> *The VS can in no way be considered a very ancient work as ancient authors do not make any reference to the VS. For instance, Halāyudha (1050 A.D.) in his Brāhmaṇasarvasva and Lakṣmīdhara (1150 A.D.) in the Kalpataru do not mention VS anywhere; nor do they quote any verse from the same whereas both the authors quote liberally from other sources. Were the VS prior to these authors, they would have certainly quoted from VS; more so because (like the VS) both the authors advocate the doctrine of Jñānakarmasamuccaya (synthesis of Knowledge and Action) for the sake of salvation in support of which they quote from different works like the Yogayājñavalkya, Agnipurāṇa etc. The absence of such quotation of*

VS in their works is an indication that VS is the later origin, i.e. after the 12th century A.D."

Compiler's note: testing the argument.

- **Lakṣmīdhara.** I checked the Mokṣakāṇḍa of the Kṛtyakalpataru in the electronic text by P. Olivelle (UT Austin, 2022; based on the edition by K. V. Rangaswami Aiyangar, GOS CII, Baroda 1945; https://sites.utexas.edu/sanskrit/resources/dharmasastra/krtyakalpataru/). Results:
  - There are indeed no verses of the VS in it. The quotations marked "vasiṣṭhaḥ" are prose rules for hermits and ascetics, not verses of the yogic VS.
  - The Yogayājñavalkya is quoted precisely in defence of the combination of knowledge and action. Chapter 15 "atha jñānakarmopayogaḥ", p. 146 by the page markers of the e-text: "yogiyājñavalkyaḥ | … jñānakarmasamāyogāt param āpnoti pūruṣam | pṛthagbhāve na sidhyeta ubhe tasmāt samāśrayet ||" ("Yogiyājñavalkya: … From the union of knowledge and action one reaches the supreme Person; it is not achieved by either separately, therefore one should resort to both"). I have confirmed this part of the editors' claim.
  - A search of the Mokṣakāṇḍa found no quotations marked as from the Agnipurāṇa. The editors may have meant other parts of the Kalpataru, or Halāyudha; this has not been checked.
  - I did not examine the other volumes of the Kalpataru.
- **Halāyudha.** I have not seen the text of the Brāhmaṇasarvasva (ed. D. Bhattacharyya, Sanskrit Sahitya Parishad Series 29, Calcutta 1960).
  - The date "1050 A.D." conflicts with other sources. According to them, the author of the Brāhmaṇasarvasva was a minister of King Lakṣmaṇasena of Bengal, 12th century: the description of the 1960 edition on exoticindiaart.com ("the court of king Lakṣmaṇasena of Bengal in the 12th century"); Swami Harshananda on hindupedia.com ("CE 1160-1200"). The same source distinguishes the lexicographer Halāyudha (10th c.) from the author of the Brāhmaṇasarvasva.
  - On these data Halāyudha lived after Lakṣmīdhara, not before him.

- **The argument itself is an argument from silence.** According to the editors, both authors quote other works in support of jñānakarmasamuccaya; had the VS existed, they would have quoted it too. Birch 2018 (n. 92) explicitly judges this argument to be inconclusive (see §4).

2.2. Upper limit: later authors quote the text

> *"That the VS is not very recent becomes evident from the fact that authors like Nāgojībhaṭṭa (end of 17th century), Bhāvāgaṇeśa (1550-1600 A.D.) Vijñānabhikṣu (1550 A.D.) etc., quote the VS, Mallīnātha (1450 A.D.) also, who preceded Vijñānabhikṣu quotes VS in his commentaries on Raghuvaṃśa and Kumārasambhava."*

Wujastyk gives independent confirmation regarding Mallinātha (see §5.5). There Mallinātha is dated "fl. 1400" rather than 1450, and the passage is given as Raghuvaṃśa 13.52.

2.3. The calculation "about 1250" from the Haṭhapradīpikā

> *"The HP also while describing the Āsanas qualifies them as recommended by sages like Vasiṣṭha etc. cf.*
>
> *"Vasiṣṭhādyaiśca munibhirmatsyendrādyaiśca yogibhiḥ*
>
> *aṅgīkṛtānyāsanāni kathyante kānicinmayā" HP. I. 18*
>
> *Thus, the VS is a work prior to the HP and if the HP is assigned to about 1350 A.D., the VS must be taken to have been ready at least before a hundred years. Thus, we can assign the VS to about 1250 A.D."*

Translation of HP 1.18: "I shall describe some of the āsanas adopted by sages beginning with Vasiṣṭha and by yogins beginning with Matsyendra."

Compiler's note.

- The dating of the Haṭhapradīpikā to "about 1350" is an assumption of the editors. More recent works date the HP to the 15th century: "Haṭhapradīpikā (15th century)" (Birch 2018, n. 92) and "circa mid-fifteenth century" (Birch 2020, p. 451).
- The interval of "a hundred years" is not justified in any way in this passage.
- HP 1.18 names Vasiṣṭha among the sages who adopted āsanas. It does not refer explicitly to the work called the Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā; the conclusion "the VS is older than the HP" was drawn by the editors.

2.4. The editors' caveat: the text is multi-layered

> *"Yet we cannot definitely state that all the material that has come down to us in the extant VS belonged to that period. Some of the material must belong to an earlier period and the VS must have attained the present form passing through various stages like the epic Jaya which attained the form of the Mahābhārata."*

Immediately after this the book has a paragraph on the lineages of teachers:

> *"The various traditions regarding the lineage of the teachers who transmitted that lore differ to a large extent. But all these (except the Mahābhārata, Śāntiparva) accounts have Vasiṣṭha and Śakti in common. The various accounts are given below."*

The lineage charts follow. In the online copy their words (Brahma, Vasistha, Sakti, Parasara, Vyasa, Suka, Gaudapada, Govinda, Sankara) were mixed into the text of the section. The printed text confirmed that the word "Sakti" is not part of the quotation about HP 1.18: OCR had inserted it from the chart.

2.5. Manuscripts and early citations (section "Extent of the Text")

> *"All the six manuscripts except one have eight chapters. The manuscript dated Samvat 1463 (i.e. 1406 A.D.), which is most authentic in this respect has eight chapters. Nrsimha Vajpeyi (1450 A.D.) quotes in his Nityacaradipa the following verse of Vasistha Yoga: […]"*

(The verse itself is illegible in the OCR.)

> *"This verse happens to be the nineteenth verse of the eighth chapter of the VS. It can be inferred that upto about 1450 A.D. the work was recognised to comprise of at least eight chapters."*

Compiler's note. The manuscript dated 1406 by itself gives only a latest date for the existence of the text (not later than 1406).

2.6. Relation to the Yogayājñavalkya and the Haṭhapradīpikā

> *"None of the scholars, quoting the stanzas found to be common to both the works, ascribe them to Yogayajnavalkya but to Vasistha. Similarly Bhavaganesa and Nagojibhatta (on Yogasutra I. 33) while quoting on the process of the purification of Nadis without Kumbhaka, ascribe it clearly to VS and not to YY. The three types of Pranayama, viz. Adhama, Madhyama and Uttama are also traced to Vasistha and not to YY. From these it becomes clear that YY is a later work and that it seems to have borrowed from VS."*

> *"The verses 11-22, of chapter V of the YY which describe the purification of Nadis, occur almost verbatim in the second chapter of the VS (V.S. 58-70). Also the words (kecit vadanti) meaning 'some say' occurring prior to verse 10 of the Vth chapter of YY seem to indicate Vasistha. From this it can be inferred that YY has borrowed from VS."*
>
> *"But the HP itself is a work later than the VS (the facts that lead us to this conclusion are given below). Hence, it can definitely be said that the VS is not a borrower."*

2.7. A discrepancy within the edition: "prior to 1150"

Checked against the printed edition. Below is the text transcribed from the printed book (section "Sūta Saṃhitā – Jñānayogakāṇḍa"). It confirms the reading "prior to 1150 A.D.", i.e. this is not an OCR error. The beginning and end of the paragraph were missing in the online copy and are restored here.

> *"**Sūta Saṃhitā- Jñānayogakāṇḍa***
>
> *The Sūta Saṃhitā has been published by the Ānandāśrama, Pune. Whilst tracing the pedigree of teachers through whom the work is handed down, the JSS states that Śakti derived the lore from Vasiṣṭha. From this it can be inferred that the JSS borrowed from the dialogue between Śakti and Vasiṣṭha. The Sūta Saṃhitā (Muktikhaṇḍa, VII. 50-55) also refers to Cakradhara Mahānubhāva and to his disciple Subhaga. Cakradhara is assigned to 1250 A.D. But as the VS (as shown below) is prior to 1150 A.D. and as there is a period of hundred years intervening between the VS and Cakradhara, the JSS is certainly the borrower from the VS. We can also point out to influence of Vedānta upon the Sūta Saṃhitā. This also proves that the JSS is later than the VS."*

This paragraph gives three arguments that the JSS is later than the VS:

3. In the JSS lineage of teachers Śakti receives the teaching from Vasiṣṭha. From this the editors infer that the JSS borrows from the dialogue of Vasiṣṭha and Śakti.
4. The Sūta Saṃhitā mentions Cakradhara Mahānubhāva, whom the editors assign to 1250. The VS, according to them, is older than 1150.
5. The influence of Vedānta is noticeable in the Sūta Saṃhitā. No concrete examples are given in this paragraph.

Compiler's note.

- Within the sentence the arithmetic is consistent: 1250 − 100 = 1150. So “1150” is not a misprint but an intended figure.
- The reference “as shown below” points to the section “Chronology”. But there a different conclusion is reached: “after the 12th century A.D.” and “we can assign the VS to about 1250 A.D.” (§§2.1, 2.3). The same book thus gives two incompatible dates for the VS: “prior to 1150” and “about 1250”. The book does not explain this discrepancy.
- Why this happened cannot be established from the printed text of 2005. One could check whether these passages agree in the 1984 edition.
- Argument (2) depends on the date. If the VS belongs to “about 1250”, it is contemporary with Cakradhara rather than a hundred years older. Then this argument for the JSS borrowing from the VS loses its force. This is my observation, not the editors'.

3. Jason Birch, 2011

Publication: Jason Birch, “The Meaning of haṭha in Early Haṭhayoga”, *Journal of the American Oriental Society* 131.4 (2011): 527–554. Open copy: https://www.themathesontrust.org/papers/hinduism/Birch-Meaning_of_hatha_in_Early_Hathayoga.pdf

In the list of early texts (p. 528): “Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā (12/13th century)”, “Yogayājñavalkya (13/14th century)”.

Note 8 (p. 528):

> *“The Kaivalyadhama Research Department (2005: 30–32) has argued convincingly that the terminus ad quem of the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā is the Yogayājñavalkya. Also, it presents evidence for a terminus a quo of the twelfth century.”*

Note 10 (p. 528):

> *“The Yogayājñavalkya's terminus a quo is the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā (see n. 8). Bouy (1994: 84) has identified a citation of the Yogayājñavalkya in the Sarvadarśanasaṅgraha, which gives it a terminus ad quem of the fourteenth century.”*

4. Jason Birch, 2018: the most detailed critical assessment

Publication: Jason Birch, “Premodern Yoga Traditions and Ayurveda: Preliminary Remarks on Shared Terminology, Theory, and Praxis”, *History of Science in South Asia*

6 (2018): 1–83. DOI: 10.18732/hssa.v6i0.25. Open PDF: https://journals.library.ualberta.ca/hssa/index.php/hssa/article/download/25/89

Note 92 (p. 25), the key passage on dating:

> *"Gérard Colas considers the Vimānārcanākalpa to be one of the earliest texts of the Vaikhānasa Saṃhitā corpus, which he dates between the 9th and 13th–14th centuries (Colas 2012:158). There is no firm terminus a quo for the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā, although the editors of the text argue for a post-12th century date, based on the absence of citations in earlier works in which they expected to find it. The Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā's terminus ad quem is the Yogayājñavalkya, which predates the Haṭhapradīpikā (15th century). Therefore, one might tentatively date the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā between the 12th-13th centuries and thus, it is possible that the Vimānārcanākalpa is older than the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā and a source text for it."*

P. 21, the scale of the Yogayājñavalkya's borrowings:

> *"The Yogayājñavalkya is a compilation and much of it is based on the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā. In fact, the former borrowed over two hundred and fifty verses from the latter."*

(In n. 81 Birch cites p. 28 of the introduction to the Kaivalyadhāma edition. Pp. 21–22 give Table 1 with parallel verses of the two texts.)

P. 25, on the source of the section on the marmans:

> *"[…] verbatim from the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā, which probably borrowed it from the Vimānārcanākalpa, a Vaikhānasa text that could date to the ninth century."*

Pp. 45–46, directly on the āsana section (VS 1.67–82, translated in this document):

> *"The āsanas of Vasiṣṭha are those described in the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā, which Svātmārāma borrowed verbatim (Mallinson 2013b:227f.)."*

> *"[…] the Vimānārcanākalpa, which is probably the source of the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā's āsanas, contains no statements on the diseases cured by āsanas."*

(N. 180: "Mallinson 2013b:227f. See also Dominik Wujastyk 2017.")

5. Dominik Wujastyk, 2017

Publication: Dominik Wujastyk, "The Yoga Texts Attributed to Yājñavalkya and their Remarks on Posture", *Asian Literature and Translation* 4.1 (2017): 159–186. DOI:

10.18573/j.2017.10192. Open copies: https://orca.cardiff.ac.uk/id/eprint/104136/ and https://ualberta.scholaris.ca/server/api/core/bitstreams/67551b96-7949-472e-bf3f-8e8d93808e6e/content

5.1. P. 162, main text and n. 18:

> *"[…] more literary research is required into the rich intertextuality of these and related works such as the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā (before 1250)."*
>
> *N. 18: "On the date of the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā see Bouy (ibid.: n. 343 et passim), Birch (2011: notes 8, 10). The section of the text on postures is translated by Mallinson and Singleton (2017: 104 f.)."*

5.2. P. 164, Bouy's conclusions on the Yogayājñavalkya:

> *"Taking earlier scholarship into account, Bouy made the following key assertions about the Yogayājñavalkya(gītā): • it is later than the Sarvayogasamuccaya in the Yogayājñavalkya, • it owes a great deal to the earlier Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā, and • it is datable to the period between about 900 and 1350."*

(N. 33: "Bouy 1994: n. 360".)

5.3. P. 164, n. 35:

> *"Birch (2011: 528, no. 8) noted that Maheshananda et al. (2005) presented evidence for thinking that the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā is twelfth century or later. This would narrow the Yogayājñavalkya(gītā)'s date to the range 1100–1350."*

5.4. P. 164, on the Vimānārcanākalpa as a common source:

> *"One of the earliest works in this canon, the Vimānārcanākalpa, contains material that is similar to passages in the Vāsiṣṭhasaṃhitā as well as to texts from the Ahirbudhnyasaṃhitā of the Pāñcarātra Corpus. If the Vimānārcanākalpa is datable to about 900 ce, as Colas (ibid.) suggests, then it is likely that all these works, including the Yogayājñavalkya(gītā), can trace parts of their content to this source."*

Ibid., n. 36: "Nine postures are described: Brāhmya, Svastika, Padma, Gomukha, Siṃha, Mukta, Vīra, Bhadra and Mayūra." Eight of these names coincide with the āsanas of VS 1.67–82.

5.5. P. 174, Mallinātha ascribes the verse on vīrāsana to Vasiṣṭha:

> *“It was also known by name to Kālidāsa, but interestingly, his commentator Mallinātha (fl. 1400) cites a verse describing how to adopt the posture that is identical to our Yogayājñavalkya(gītā) verse. But Mallinātha ascribes it to Vasiṣṭha.”*
>
> *N. 63: “The reference is to the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā, that was also cited multiple times by the late-sixteenth-century yoga commentator Vijñānabhikṣu (Digambaraji, Jha, and Sahay 1984: 14), including on Pātañjalayogaśāstra 2.46.”*

(The passage in Mallinātha is Raghuvaṃśa 13.52, n. 62.)

6. Jason Birch, 2020

Publication: Jason Birch, “Haṭhayoga's Floruit on the Eve of Colonialism”, in: *Śaivism and the Tantric Traditions: Essays in Honour of Alexis G. J. S. Sanderson*, Brill, 2020, pp. 451–479. DOI: 10.1163/9789004432802_021 (open access, CC BY-NC). https://brill.com/display/book/edcoll/9789004432802/BP000024.xml

Note 6:

> *“This Vaiṣṇava form of aṣṭāṅgayoga is taught (without the Haṭhayogic mudrās) in the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā and Yogayājñavalkya, which were probably composed in the twelfth and fourteenth centuries, respectively.”*

7. S. V. B. K. V. Gupta, Jason Birch, 2022

Publication: S. V. B. K. V. Gupta, Jason Birch, “The Ocean of Yoga: An Unpublished Compendium Called the Yogārṇava”, *Journal of Indian Philosophy* 50 (2022): 345–385. DOI: 10.1007/s10781-022-09504-6 (open access). Section “Possible Source Texts of the Yogārṇava”.

> *“There is a complex relationship between the Yogārṇava, Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā (12th c.) and Yogayājñavalkya (13th–14th c.). The editors of the Kaivalyadhama Yoga Institute's critical edition of the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā (2005: 31–32) argue that the Yogayājñavalkya borrowed much material from it. This hypothesis is supported by a comparison of parallel passages in both works that was published in Birch (2018, pp. 21–22), which demonstrated that the redactor of the Yogayājñavalkya borrowed a lengthy discussion on the yogic body from the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā and supplemented it with material from elsewhere. Therefore, the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā is probably the earlier work, which the editors of the Kaivalyadhama Yoga Institute's edition date to the twelfth century.”*

Compiler's note. In the section “Chronology” the Kaivalyadhāma editors themselves write “after the 12th century” and “about 1250 A.D.”, i.e. the middle of the 13th century (§§2.1, 2.3). Gupta and Birch's wording “date to the twelfth century” disagrees with this. Note 7 of the same article refers to Birch 2011, p. 528, nn. 8 and 10. Note 15 gives Bouy's pages on texts that borrow from the VS: “Bouy (1994), 13 n. 19, 17 n. 38, 67 n. 293, 68, 82”.

8. James Mallinson, Mark Singleton, 2017

Publication: James Mallinson, Mark Singleton, *Roots of Yoga*. London: Penguin Classics, 2017. ISBN 978-0-241-25304-5.

In the timeline at the beginning of the book (“Timeline of Important Texts”) the Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā appears in the 13th-century row (diacritics normalised):

> *“13th century CE | Saṅgītaratnākara (ŚT), Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā (H), Candrāvalokana (H), Matsyendrasaṃhitā (ŚT), Vivekamārtaṇḍa (H), Gorakṣaśataka (H), Dattātreyayogaśāstra (H), Jñāneśvarī (H)”*

In the same timeline “Vimānārcanākalpa (VT)” appears in the row “6th–10th century CE” among the early tantras. According to Wujastyk (nn. 18, 36), the VS section on āsanas is translated on pp. 104 ff., and the āsanas of the Vimānārcanākalpa on pp. 100 ff. The English Wikipedia cites pp. 87–88 and 104–105 of this book for the statement that the VS uses the Vimānārcanākalpa. I have not seen the text of these pages; they need to be checked in the book.

9. Ruth Westoby

Publication: Ruth Westoby, *The Body in Early Haṭha Yoga* (study published on wisdomlib.org, 2024), section “The Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā and Haṭha Yoga”: https://www.wisdomlib.org/hinduism/essay/the-body-in-early-hatha-yoga/d/doc1500707.html

> *“The thirteenth-century Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā is a dialogue between the sage Vasiṣṭha and his son Śakti. […] Over 250 verses of the Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā were borrowed by the Yogayājñavalkya and both are derived from earlier vaiṣṇava works such as the Vimānārcanākalpa (Mallinson 2014:227–8) and pāñcarātrika texts, such as the Ahirbudhnyasaṃhitā (Birch 2020b:210).”*

10. Christian Bouy, 1994

Publication: Christian Bouy, *Les Nātha-yogin et les Upaniṣads: étude d'histoire de la littérature hindoue*. Paris: De Boccard, 1994.

I have not found an online text of this book, so there are no direct quotations. Below are the places cited by other authors:

- n. 343 et passim: on the date of the VS (Wujastyk 2017, n. 18);
- p. 84: a citation of the Yogayājñavalkya in the Sarvadarśanasaṅgraha, which gives the 14th century as the upper limit for the Yogayājñavalkya (Birch 2011, n. 10);
- n. 360: conclusions on the Yogayājñavalkya, including its dependence on the VS (Wujastyk 2017, n. 33);
- p. 13 n. 19, p. 17 n. 38, p. 67 n. 293, p. 68, p. 82: texts that borrow from the VS (Gupta & Birch 2022, n. 15).

11. A separate question: the entry in Aufrecht's catalogue

In T. Aufrecht's *Catalogus Catalogorum* (in the digitisation of the University of Cologne, reproduced on wisdomlib.org) the entry for the yogic Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā reads:

> *"Vasiṣṭhasaṃhitā: — yoga. Io. 2609 (in 8 chapters). Quoted by Śaṅkarācārya on Śvetāśvataropaniṣad, by Narasiṃha in Tārābhaktisudhārṇava, Catal. Io. p. 898."*

Link: https://www.wisdomlib.org/definition/vasishthasamhita (original: https://www.sanskrit-lexicon.uni-koeln.de/scans/ACCScan/2020/web/index.php).

Compiler's note. Taken literally, this entry conflicts with all the datings above. Neither the Kaivalyadhāma introduction (in the online copy) nor the articles in §§3–9 discuss this point. I have not checked which verse is quoted in the commentary on the Śvetāśvatara. The attribution of the commentary itself to Śaṅkara is disputed by scholars; see, for example, Ivan Andrijanić, "Śaṅkara and the authorship of Śvetāśvataropaniṣad-Bhāṣya", *Journal of Hindu Studies* 12.3: https://academic.oup.com/jhs/article-abstract/12/3/273/5071712. I have not seen the conclusions of this article; only the abstract is accessible.

12. What to check first

6. The Kaivalyadhāma introduction (2005): the sections "Suta Samhita – Jnanayogakanda" (§2.7) and "Chronology" (§§2.1–2.4) have already been checked against the printed book. The sections "Extent of the Text" and "Limitations of Vasistha Samhita" (§§2.5–2.6, pp. 27–31 of the online copy) remain to be checked. It is especially important to recover the verse quoted by Nṛsiṃha Vājapeyī, which is illegible in the OCR.

7. Birch 2018, n. 92 (p. 25): the only place I found where the editors' argument is explicitly judged inconclusive (“There is no firm terminus a quo”).
8. Birch 2011, nn. 8 and 10 (p. 528).
9. Wujastyk 2017, pp. 162, 164, 174.
10. Bouy 1994, nn. 343 and 360, p. 84.

Āsanas of the Vasiṣṭha Saṃhitā (ch. 1, vv. 67–82)

Introductory verse: list of āsanas

Devanāgarī

आसनानि च वक्ष्यामि शृणु पुत्र समाहितः । स्वस्तिकं गोमुखं पद्मं वीरं सिंहासनं तथा । मायूरं कुक्कुटं चैव कूर्मं भद्रासनं तथा । मुक्तासनं तथा तेषां पृथक् वक्ष्यामि लक्षणम् ॥ ६७ ॥

IAST

āsanāni ca vakṣyāmi śṛṇu putra samāhitaḥ । svastikaṃ gomukhaṃ padmaṃ vīraṃ siṃhāsanaṃ tathā । māyūraṃ kukkuṭaṃ caiva kūrmaṃ bhadrāsanaṃ tathā । muktāsanaṃ tathā teṣāṃ pṛthak vakṣyāmi lakṣaṇam ॥ 67 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

āсанāни ча вакшйāми ш́рṇу путра самāхитаҳ । свастикаṃ гомукхаṃ падмаṃ вӣраṃ сиṃхāсанаṃ татхā । мāйӯраṃ куккуṭаṃ чаива кӯрмаṃ бхадрāсанаṃ татхā । муктāсанаṃ татхā тешāṃ пṛтхак вакшйāми лакшаṇам ॥ 67 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

āsanāni – āsanas; ca – and, also; vakṣyāmi – I shall explain; śṛṇu – listen; putra – O son; samāhitaḥ – concentrated, attentive; svastikam – Svastika; gomukham – Gomukha; padmam – Padma (Lotus); vīram – Vīra (Hero); siṃhāsanam – Siṃhāsana; tathā – also; māyūram – Māyūra (the peacock [pose]); kukkuṭam – Kukkuṭa (the cock [pose]); ca eva – and also; kūrmam – Kūrma (the tortoise [pose]); bhadrāsanam – Bhadrāsana; tathā – also; muktāsanam – Muktāsana; tathā – also; teṣām – of them; pṛthak – separately; vakṣyāmi – I shall explain; lakṣaṇam – distinguishing mark, definition.

Literal translation

And I shall explain the āsanas [to you] – listen attentively, son: Svastika, Gomukha, Padma, Vīra, and also Siṃhāsana, Māyūra, Kukkuṭa, and also Kūrma and Bhadrāsana, and also Muktāsana; I shall explain the definition of each of them separately.

Literary translation

Vasiṣṭha promises his son to explain the āsanas and names ten postures: Svastika, Gomukha, Padma, Vīra, Siṃhāsana, Māyūra, Kukkuṭa, Kūrma, Bhadrāsana and Muktāsana – in order to describe each of them separately afterwards. (In the edition's English translation Kūrma is omitted from the list; in the descriptions below Bhadrāsana comes before Kūrmāsana.)

1. Svastikāsana (“Svastika Pose”, “Auspicious Pose”)

Devanāgarī

जानूर्वोरन्तरं सम्यक् कृत्वा पादतले उभे । ऋजुकायस्तथासीनः स्वस्तिकं तत् प्रचक्षते ॥ ६८ ॥

IAST

jānūrvor antaraṃ samyak kṛtvā pādatale ubhe । ṛjukāyas tathāsīnaḥ svastikaṃ tat pracakṣate ॥ 68 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

джа̄нӯрвор антараṃ самйак кр̣тва̄ па̄датале убхе । р̣джука̄йас татха̄сӣнаḥ свастикаṃ тат прачакшате ॥ 68 ॥

Devanāgarī

सीवन्यामात्मनः पार्श्वे गुल्फौ निक्षिप्य पादयोः । एतद्वा स्वस्तिकं प्रोक्तं सर्वपापप्रणाशनम् ॥ ६९ ॥

IAST

sīvanyām ātmanaḥ pārśve gulphau nikṣipya pādayoḥ । etad vā svastikaṃ proktaṃ sarvapāpapraṇāśanam ॥ 69 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

сӣванйа̄м а̄тманаḥ па̄рш́ве гулпхау никшипйа па̄дайоḥ । етад ва̄ свастикаṃ проктаṃ сарвапа̄папраṇа̄ш́анам ॥ 69 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

jānu-ūrvoḥ – of the knees and thighs; antaram – [into] the space, between (other texts read «अन्तरे», “in the space”); samyak – properly, correctly; kṛtvā – having placed (lit. having made); pāda-tale – the two soles; ubhe – both; ṛju-kāyaḥ – with the body straight; tathā – thus; āsīnaḥ – seated; svastikam – Svastika; tat – that, this; pracakṣate – they call.

sīvanyām – at the seam (perineum); ātmanaḥ – one's own; pārśve – at the side; gulphau – both ankles; nikṣipya – having placed; pādayoḥ – of [both] feet; etat – this; vā – or else, also; svastikam – Svastika; proktam – is called; sarva-pāpa-praṇāśanam – destroying all sins.

Literal translation

Having properly placed both soles between the knees and thighs, and sitting thus with the body straight – this they call Svastika. Or else, having placed the ankles of [both] feet at the sides of one's own perineum – this too is called Svastika, which destroys all sins.

Literary translation

Svastikāsana – the Auspicious Pose. One sits with the body straight, tucking the soles of both feet into the spaces between the calves and thighs of the opposite legs. Another variant: the ankles are placed on either side of the perineum. The pose destroys all sins.

2. Gomukhāsana (“Cow-Face Pose”)

Devanāgarī

सव्ये दक्षिणगुल्फं तु पृष्ठपार्श्वे निवेशयेत् । दक्षिणेऽपि तथा सव्यं गोमुखं तत् प्रचक्षते ॥ ७० ॥

IAST

savye dakṣiṇagulphaṃ tu pṛṣṭhapārśve niveśayet । dakṣiṇe 'pi tathā savyaṃ gomukhaṃ tat pracakṣate ॥ 70 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

савйе дакшиṇагулпхаṃ ту пр̣шт̣хапāрш́ве нивеш́айет । дакшиṇе 'пи татхā савйаṃ гомукхаṃ тат прачакшате ॥ 70 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

savye – on the left, on the left [side]; dakṣiṇa-gulpham – the right ankle (in the file: «दक्षिणगुल्कं» – OCR error); tu – indeed; pṛṣṭha-pārśve – beside the back (by the buttock); niveśayet – one should place; dakṣiṇe – on the right; api – and; tathā – likewise; savyam – the left [ankle]; gomukham – Gomukha; tat – that, this; pracakṣate – they call.

Literal translation

One should place the right ankle on the left, beside the back, and likewise the left on the right; this they call Gomukha.

Literary translation

Gomukhāsana – the Cow-Face Pose. The right ankle is placed by the left side, next to the buttock, and the left one likewise by the right side.

3. Padmāsana (“Lotus Pose”)

Devanāgarī

अङ्गुष्ठौ च निबध्नीयाद्धस्ताभ्यां व्युत्क्रमेण तु । ऊर्वोरुपरि विप्रेन्द्र कृत्वा पादतले उभे । पद्मासनं भवेदेतत् सर्वेषामेव पूजितम् ॥ ७१ ॥

IAST

aṅguṣṭhau ca nibadhnīyād dhastābhyāṃ vyutkrameṇa tu । ūrvor upari viprendra kṛtvā pādatale ubhe । padmāsanaṃ bhaved etat sarveṣām eva pūjitam ॥ 71 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

аṅгушт̣хау ча нибадхнӣйād дхастābхйāṃ вйуткрамеṇа ту । ӯрвор упари випрендра кр̣твā пāдатале убхе । падмāсанаṃ бхавед етат сарвешāм ева пӯджитам ॥ 71 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

aṅguṣṭhau – both big toes [of the feet]; ca – and; nibadhnīyāt – one should grasp (lit. bind); hastābhyām – with the hands; vyutkrameṇa – in reverse order, crosswise; tu – indeed; ūrvoḥ – of the thighs; upari – on top of; viprendra – O best of brāhmaṇas; kṛtvā – having placed (lit. having made); pāda-tale – the two soles; ubhe – both; padmāsanam – Padmāsana; bhavet – will be; etat – this; sarveṣām – by all; eva – indeed, truly; pūjitam – revered.

Literal translation

And one should grasp the big toes with the hands crosswise, O best of brāhmaṇas, having placed both soles on top of the thighs. This will be Padmāsana, revered by all.

Literary translation

Padmāsana – the Lotus Pose. The soles of both feet are placed on the thighs, and the big toes are grasped with crossed hands (the edition's English translation specifies that the arms are brought behind the back). This pose is revered by all.

4. Vīrāsana (“Hero Pose”)

Devanāgarī

एकं पादमथैकस्मिन् विन्यस्योरौ च संस्थितम् । इतरस्मिंस्तथैवोरुं वीरासनमितीरितम् ॥ ७२ ॥

IAST

ekaṃ pādam athaikasmin vinyasyorau ca saṃsthitam । itarasmiṃs tathaivoruṃ vīrāsanam itīritam ॥ 72 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

екаṃ пāдам атхаикасмин винйасйорау ча саṃстхитам । итарасмиṃс татхаиворуṃ вӣрāсанам итӣритам ॥ 72 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

ekam – one; pādam – foot; atha – then; ekasmin – on one; vinyasya – having placed; ūrau – on the thigh; ca – and; saṃsthitam – firmly set; itarasmin – on the other [foot]; tathā eva – in exactly the same way; ūrum – the thigh; vīrāsanam – Vīrāsana; iti – thus; īritam – is called.

Literal translation

Having placed one foot on one thigh and set [it] firmly, and on the other [foot] in exactly the same way the [other] thigh – [this] is called Vīrāsana.

Literary translation

Vīrāsana – the Hero Pose. One foot is firmly placed on the thigh of the opposite leg, and the other thigh is likewise placed over the second foot.

5. Siṃhāsana (“Lion Pose”)

Devanāgarī

गुल्फौ च वृषणस्याधः सीवन्याः पार्श्वयोः क्षिपेत् । दक्षिणं सव्यगुल्फेन दक्षिणेनेतरेतरम् ॥ ७३ ॥

IAST

gulphau ca vṛṣaṇasyādhaḥ sīvanyāḥ pārśvayoḥ kṣipet । dakṣiṇaṃ savyagulphena dakṣiṇenetaretaram ॥ 73 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

гулпхау ча вр̣шаṇасйādхаḥ сӣванйāḥ пāрш́вайоḥ кшипет । дакшиṇаṃ савйагулпхена дакшиṇенетаретарам ॥ 73 ॥

Devanāgarī

हस्तौ जानौ च संस्थाप्य स्वाङ्गुलीश्च प्रसार्य च । व्यात्तवक्त्रो निरीक्षेत नासाग्रं सुसमाहितः ॥ ७४ ॥

IAST

hastau jānau ca saṃsthāpya svāṅgulīś ca prasārya ca । vyāttavaktro nirīkṣeta nāsāgraṃ susamāhitaḥ ॥ 74 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

хастау джāнау ча саṃстхāпйа свāṅгулӣш́ ча прасāрйа ча । вйāттавактро нирӣкшета нāсāграṃ сусамāхитаḥ ॥ 74 ॥

Devanāgarī

सिंहासनं भवेदेतत् पूजितं योगिभिः सदा ॥ ७५ ॥

IAST

siṃhāsanaṃ bhaved etat pūjitaṃ yogibhiḥ sadā ॥ 75 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

сиṃхāсанаṃ бхавед етат пӯджитаṃ йогибхиḥ садā ॥ 75 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

gulphau – both ankles; ca – and; vṛṣaṇasya – of the scrotum; adhaḥ – below; sīvanyāḥ – of the seam (perineum); pārśvayoḥ – on both sides; kṣipet – one should place; dakṣiṇam – the right [side]; savya-gulphena – with the left ankle; dakṣiṇena – with the right [ankle]; itaretaram – the other, opposite [side].

hastau – both hands; jānau – on the knee (sing.; in sense – on the knees); ca – and; saṃsthāpya – having set; sva-aṅgulīḥ – one's fingers (in the file: «स्वाङ्गुलीश्च» – OCR error); ca – and; prasārya – having spread, stretched out; ca – and; vyātta-vaktraḥ – with the mouth wide open; nirīkṣeta – one should gaze; nāsa-agram – at the tip of the nose; su-samāhitaḥ – well concentrated.

siṃhāsanam – Siṃhāsana; bhavet – will be; etat – this; pūjitam – revered; yogibhiḥ – by yogins; sadā – always.

Literal translation

One should place both ankles below the scrotum on both sides of the perineum: the right [side] with the left ankle, the other with the right. Having set the hands on the knees and spread one's fingers, with the mouth wide open, well concentrated, one should gaze at the tip of the nose. This will be Siṃhāsana, always revered by yogins.

Literary translation

Siṃhāsana – the Lion Pose. The ankles are placed crosswise below the scrotum on either side of the perineum: the left ankle is pressed against the right side of the perineum, the right one against the left. The palms rest on the knees with the fingers spread wide; the mouth is wide open, the gaze is directed at the tip of the nose, and the mind is collected. Yogins always revere this pose.

6. Mayūrāsana (“Peacock Pose”)

Devanāgarī

अवष्टभ्य धरां सम्यक् तलाभ्यां च करद्वयम् । हस्तयोः खपरे चापि स्थापयेन्नाभिपार्श्वयोः ॥ ७६ ॥

IAST

avaṣṭabhya dharāṃ samyak talābhyāṃ ca karadvayam । hastayoḥ kharpare cāpi sthāpayen nābhipārśvayoḥ ॥ 76 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

авашṭабхйа дхарāṃ самйак талāбхйāṃ ча карадвайам । хастайоḥ кхарпаре чāпи стхāпайен нāбхипāрш́вайоḥ ॥ 76 ॥

Devanāgarī

समुन्नतशिरःपादो दण्डवद्व्योम्नि संस्थितः । मयूरासनमेतद्धि सर्वपापविनाशनम् ॥ ७७ ॥

IAST

samunnataśiraḥpādo daṇḍavad vyomni saṃsthitaḥ । mayūrāsanam etad dhi sarvapāpavināśanam ॥ 77 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

самуннаташ́ираҳпāдо даṇдавад вйомни саṃстхитаҳ । майӯрāсанам етад дхи сарвапāпавинāш́анам ॥ 77 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

avaṣṭabhya – pressing against; dharām – the ground (in the file: «घरां» – OCR error); samyak – properly, firmly; talābhyām – with the palms; ca – and; kara-dvayam – [of both] hands, the pair of hands; hastayoḥ – of the hands; kharpare – the elbows (so in the edition: «खपरे»; by sense and according to the English translation – «कूपरे», “elbows”); ca api – and also; sthāpayet – one should place (in the file's Devanāgarī: «स्थापयन्», “placing”; in the edition's IAST – «sthāpayen»); nābhi-pārśvayoḥ – on both sides of the navel.

samunnata-śiraḥ-pādaḥ – with head and feet raised high; daṇḍavat – like a stick; vyomni – in the air, in space (in the file: «व्योनि» – OCR error); saṃsthitaḥ – remaining;

mayūrāsanam – Mayūrāsana; etat – this; hi – truly; sarva-pāpa-vināśanam – destroying all sins.

Literal translation

Having firmly pressed the ground with the palms of both hands and placed the elbows on both sides of the navel, with head and feet raised high, remaining in the air like a stick – this, truly, is Mayūrāsana, which destroys all sins.

Literary translation

Mayūrāsana – the Peacock Pose. The palms of both hands are pressed firmly into the ground, and the elbows are set at the sides of the navel; the head and legs are raised, and the body is held horizontally in the air like a stick. The pose destroys all sins.

7. Kukkuṭāsana (“Cock Pose”)

Devanāgarī

पद्मासनं समास्थाय जानूर्वोरन्तरे करौ । भूमौ निवेश्य संस्थाप्य व्योमस्थं कुक्कुटासनम् ॥ ७८ ॥

IAST

padmāsanaṃ samāsthāya jānūrvor antare karau । bhūmau niveśya saṃsthāpya vyomasthaṃ kukkuṭāsanam ॥ 78 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

падмāсанаṃ самāстхāйа джāнӯрвор антаре карау । бхӯмау нивеш́йа саṃстхāпйа вйомастхаṃ куккуṭāсанам ॥ 78 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

padmāsanam – Padmāsana; samāsthāya – having assumed; jānu-ūrvoḥ – of the knees and thighs (in the file: «जानूवोर्» – OCR error); antare – into the space, between; karau – both hands; bhūmau – on the ground; niveśya – having inserted, placed; saṃsthāpya – having set [the body]; vyoma-stham – remaining in the air; kukkuṭāsanam – Kukkuṭāsana.

Literal translation

Having assumed Padmāsana, inserted the hands between the knees and thighs, placed [them] on the ground and set [the body] in the air – [this is] Kukkuṭāsana.

Literary translation

Kukkuṭāsana – the Cock Pose. Sitting in Padmāsana, one pushes the hands through between the calves and thighs, presses the palms into the ground and lifts the body into the air.

8. Bhadrāsana (“Auspicious Pose”)

Devanāgarī

गुल्फौ च वृषणस्याधः सीवन्याः पार्श्वयोः क्षिपन् । पार्श्वपादौ च पाणिभ्यां दृढं बद्ध्वा सुनिश्चलम् । भद्रासनं भवेदेतत् सर्वव्याधिविषापहम् ॥ ७९ ॥

IAST

gulphau ca vṛṣaṇasyādhaḥ sīvanyāḥ pārśvayoḥ kṣipan । pārśvapādau ca pāṇibhyāṃ dṛḍhaṃ baddhvā suniścalam । bhadrāsanaṃ bhaved etat sarvavyādhiviṣāpaham ॥ 79 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

гулпхау ча вр̣шаṇасйādдхаx̣ сйванйāx̣ пāрш́вайоx̣ кшипан । пāрш́вапāдау ча пāṇибхйāṃ др̣дхаṃ баддхвā суниш́чалам । бхадрāсанаṃ бхавед етат сарвавйādхивишāпахам ॥ 79 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

gulphau – both ankles (in the file: «गुल्फी» – OCR error); ca – and; vṛṣaṇasya – of the scrotum; adhaḥ – below; sīvanyāḥ – of the seam (perineum); pārśvayoḥ – on both sides; kṣipan – placing; pārśva-pādau – the feet [that end up] at the sides; ca – and; pāṇibhyām – with the hands; dṛḍham – firmly; baddhvā – having clasped (lit. having bound); su-niścalam – completely motionless; bhadrāsanam – Bhadrāsana; bhavet – will be; etat – this; sarva-vyādhi-viṣa-apaham – removing all diseases and poisons.

Literal translation

Placing both ankles below the scrotum on both sides of the perineum and firmly, completely motionless, clasping with the hands the feet [that end up] at the sides – this will be Bhadrāsana, which removes all diseases and poisons.

Literary translation

Bhadrāsana – the Auspicious Pose. The ankles are placed below the scrotum on either side of the perineum; the feet, now at the sides, are clasped firmly with the hands, and one sits completely still. The pose frees one from all diseases and from the effects of poisons.

9. Kūrmāsana (“Tortoise Pose”)

Devanāgarī

गुदं निरुध्य गुल्फाभ्यां व्युत्क्रमेण समाहितः । कूर्मासनं भवेदेतदिति योगविदो विदुः ॥ ८० ॥

IAST

gudaṃ nirudhya gulphābhyāṃ vyutkrameṇa samāhitaḥ । kūrmāsanaṃ bhaved etad iti yogavido viduḥ ॥ 80 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

гудаṃ нирудхйа гулпхāбхйāṃ вйуткрамеṇа самāхитаḥ । кӯрмāсанаṃ бхавед етад ити йогавидо видуḥ ॥ 80 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

gudam – the anus; nirudhya – having blocked, restrained; gulphābhyām – with both ankles; vyutkrameṇa – in reverse order, crosswise; samāhitaḥ – concentrated; kūrmāsanam – Kūrmāsana; bhavet – will be; etat – this; iti – thus; yoga-vidaḥ – the knowers of yoga; viduḥ – know.

Literal translation

Having blocked the anus with both ankles [placed] crosswise, concentrated – this will be Kūrmāsana; so the knowers of yoga know.

Literary translation

Kūrmāsana – the Tortoise Pose. The anus is pressed and closed with the crossed ankles, and one sits collected and concentrated. So teach the knowers of yoga.

10. Muktāsana (“Pose of the Liberated”)

Devanāgarī

मेढ्रादुपरि निक्षिप्य सव्यं गुल्फं तथोपरि । गुल्फान्तरं विनिक्षिप्य मुक्तासनमिदं स्मृतम् ॥ ८१ ॥

IAST

meḍhrād upari nikṣipya savyaṃ gulphaṃ tathopari । gulphāntaraṃ vinikṣipya muktāsanam idaṃ smṛtam ॥ 81 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

медҳрāд упари никшипйа савйаṃ гулпхаṃ татхопари । гулпхāнтараṃ виникшипйа муктāсанам идаṃ смр̣там ॥ 81 ॥

Devanāgarī

सम्पीड्य सीवनीं सूक्ष्मां गुल्फेनैव तु सव्यतः । सव्यं दक्षिणगुल्फेन मुक्तासनमिदं तु वा ॥ ८२ ॥

IAST

sampīḍya sīvanīṃ sūkṣmāṃ gulphenaiva tu savyataḥ । savyaṃ dakṣiṇagulphena muktāsanam idaṃ tu vā ॥ 82 ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

сампӣдйа сӣванӣṃ сӯкшмāṃ гулпхенаива ту савйатаҳ । савйаṃ дакшиṇагулпхена муктāсанам идаṃ ту вā ॥ 82 ॥

Word-by-word analysis

meḍhrāt – the penis (abl.: “than the penis”); upari – above; nikṣipya – having placed; savyam – the left; gulpham – ankle; tathā – likewise; upari – on top; gulpha-antaram – the other ankle; vinikṣipya – having laid; muktāsanam – Muktāsana; idam – this; smṛtam – is known, prescribed [by tradition].

sampīḍya – having pressed; sīvanīm – the seam, perineum (in the file: «सीवनी» – OCR error); sūkṣmām – fine, thin; gulphena – with the ankle; eva tu – indeed; savyataḥ –

the left (lit. from the left side); savyam – the left [ankle] (the English translation understands: “the left side of the perineum”); dakṣiṇa-gulphena – with the right ankle; muktāsanam – Muktāsana; idam – this; tu – indeed; vā – or, also.

Literal translation

Having placed the left ankle above the penis and likewise laid the other ankle on top [of it] – this is known as Muktāsana. Having pressed the fine seam (perineum) with the ankle – the left one, and the left [ankle] with the right ankle: this too is Muktāsana.

Literary translation

Muktāsana – the Pose of the Liberated. The left ankle is placed above the genitals (at the pubic bone), and the right one on top of it. Another variant: the perineum is pressed with the left ankle, and the right ankle is placed on the left one.